
What to Expect for a Spinal Tap

Why do we do a spinal tap?

- To check for **inflammation or infection** of the brain or spinal cord
- Usually done right after an **MRI** to rule out other problems

An MRI gives us pictures, but it cannot give us a sample. Taking a tissue sample from the brain or spinal cord is difficult and risky. A spinal tap is the **closest way to sample the nervous system without surgery**.

The procedure

Your pet is under **general anesthesia**. A small area is shaved and cleaned, and a needle is used to collect a small amount of spinal fluid (cerebrospinal fluid, CSF) from one of two places:

- **High tap** (cerebellomedullary cistern) — at the **base of the skull**
- **Low tap** (lumbar cistern) — in the **lower back**

Your neurologist chooses the safest, most useful site for your pet's condition.

What happens to the fluid?

It is sent to a laboratory for:

- **Fluid analysis** — protein level and cell examination
- **Infectious disease testing** (viral, fungal, protozoal) when needed
- **Special tests** if warranted, such as PARR for lymphoma

After the spinal tap

- Unlike people, pets rarely get headaches or other side effects.
- **Serious complications are rare (less than 1%).**
- Most pets eat soon after the procedure.
- The shaved area may look a little red or bruised for a few days.

Contact us if your pet stops eating, seems painful, or shows new weakness or other neurological signs.

More information: search "Cerebrospinal Fluid Collection and Examination" at vcahospitals.com.